

by design', 'inclusive design', and 'universal access'.

Most developed countries have their own DPIs. For instance, Estonia, a tech pioneer, has the X-Road digital infrastructure that enables the government to provide 99 per cent of public services online. France had FranceConnect, its central ID authority, made available free of charge, allowing citizens to use an existing credential to identify themselves electronically to other digital services.

But the inflection point for digital services came with the outbreak of Covid-19. First there was the test and track systems that countries—including India—that had the know-how deployed. Then there was the roll-out of the vaccination programme. Kunal Walia, Partner at Dalberg Advisors, says, "The pandemic created a demand for DPI in health, only amplified by the success of India's vaccination DPI." He adds that India set an example with its direct benefit transfers to more than 160 million beneficiaries within a month of the Covid-19 outbreak, "while countries like Germany, known for their advancements in technological development, were not able to reach their citizens".

The attractions of DPI are obvious. It can help provide citizen services at scale, and at low cost. Interoperability allows a multitude of third-party solutions to be built on top of the existing architecture, fostering innovation. But even in this large field of DPIs available globally, India DPI appeals to many countries, say experts, as some problems that it is solving around identity, payments, healthcare, and education, and at scale, are common in developing countries.

"These solutions have been in use in India for more than 10 years



“WE’RE HELPING NATIONS BUILD THEIR OWN DPI”

Union Minister of State Rajeev Chandrasekhar talks about India's DPI, the interest in it from other countries and the government's plans for it **BY NIDHI SINGAL**



PHOTO BY GETTY IMAGES

RAJEEV CHANDRASEKHAR, Minister of State in the Ministry of Electronics and IT (MeitY), talks to *Business Today* about the deep interest many countries have shown in adopting India's Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI), and what the government is planning to add to the India Stack. Edited excerpts:

►►► ***When you took charge of MeitY in 2021, you had a 1,000-day agenda. With less than 200 days remaining, how has the progress been so far?***

I think we've made tremendous progress in six broad areas. If I am giving myself a report card, I think we've made decent prog-

ress on the legislative side, rules side. The Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act has been passed. The digital economy today, if you see the latest GDP numbers as well, is firing on all cylinders. We are at about 11 per cent of GDP today. And by 2026, we will be at about 20 per cent. Electronics manufacturing has made a significant leap. The target we set when I came on board [was] about \$300 billion of electronics manufacturing and \$120 billion of exports. While we may not be able to meet it by 2025-26, we are certainly on track to get to those numbers and expand our presence in the electronics global value chains in a manner